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Esports is India's next big growth story

At Sportstar's PlayCom 2025: Business of Sports Summit in New Delhi, Dilsher Singh Malhi (above), Founder and CEO of Zupee, said India's new online gaming regulations mark a turning point for the industry.

"The new online gaming regulations have done more than just regulate — they have recognised esports as a competitive sport, giving it the legitimacy and clarity it deserves. This sets the stage for something truly transformative, and shows the government's intent to develop esports in India," Malhi said.

He argued that regulations are only the beginning. "Every law needs vision, and every vision needs enablers — people who can turn ideas into reality. We believe Zupee plays that role."

Zupee already has a vast user base, Malhi noted, with over 200 million registered players engaged

in culturally rooted games. "This is a ready community that can transition from casual play to competitive formats. For instance, we've taken Ludo — a game every Indian knows — and reimagined it as a skill-based format where strategy and focus are key. In doing so, we've brought millions into competitive play."

Malhi stressed that India's esports future lies in mobile-first innovation. "In India, there are fewer than 10 million gaming consoles, but over 750 million smartphones. Any kind of innovation needs to keep that in mind."

According to him, esports has the power to transform India across three dimensions — employment, technology, and culture. "Just as cricket has created an economy of coaches, broadcasters, content

creators, and commentators, esports will do the same. Gaming has always been the gateway for new technologies to break through. And why can't there be a World Cup around Ludo? Anime did it for Japan, K-pop for Korea — India has the same opportunity."

For Malhi, inclusivity is the defining feature of esports. "All it takes is a smartphone. The next champion can come from a metro or a Tier-2 city. That's why we believe esports is India's next big growth story."

To accelerate this vision, Zupee has launched Zupee Studio, a platform designed to blend gaming and entertainment. Malhi described it as the company's next step in driving cultural and technological innovation in the sector.

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